candidates, office-bearers and ministers, each name was individually verified by members of this core group from the constituency each politician belonged to. This meant calling a vast network of local political party chiefs, regional political leaders, local notables, university professors, journalists and other informants in each constituency. We kept records of each call, each message and every bit of information that was received from any source. Each name was verified by members of the wider Mehta–Singh Social Index Project network and then re-verified by our central project team after ascertaining the antecedents of the source. To be doubly sure, we double-checked some of this data through a parallel, blind peer-review process. The pollster Jai Mrug kindly agreed to run a pro bono caste-identification exercise for all political candidates from the BJP, SP, BSP and Congress who stood for Lok Sabha elections in UP. His agency, VMR, did so with their own team of survey researchers in each of UP's eighty constituencies for three national elections between 2009 and 2019. They did this independently of the Mehta–Singh Social Index Project team, mostly through meetings and phone calls with district-level presidents of the various parties. We then compared the two lists—prepared by two different teams with different skill sets. We cross-referenced these lists to see if there were any inconsistencies, mistakes or errors. To our pleasant surprise, the lists were mostly in agreement, but we closed important gaps through this process and gained valuable insights.

Finally, along with members of the core Mehta–Singh Social Index Project team, I travelled to several towns in UP—Lucknow, Raebareli, Amethi, Etah, Fatehpur, Kaushambi, Mainpuri, Pratapgarh, etc.—and checked early versions of the list with local politicians across party lines (BJP, SP, Congress and BSP, independent) as well with experienced Hindi journalists in the districts. The core team did a final round of checks with local political leaders in each district. At each stage, we found some corrections in the caste lists, which taught us valuable lessons in the complexity of caste names in UP. 'There is a bhayaanak [terrible] confusion on many OBC jaati names,' one pollster told us. By the end, though, the checks and balances we built into this exercise made us supremely confident that the Mehta–Singh Social Index is by far the most